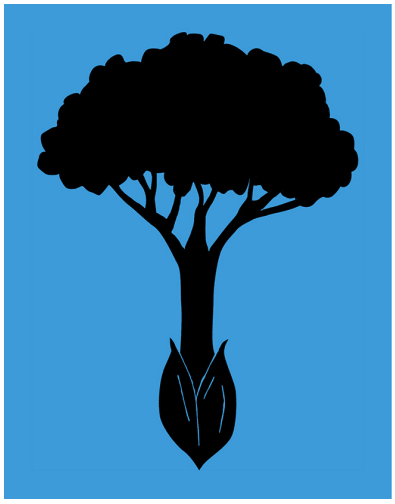


I HAVE GREAT FAITH IN A SEED

ECOLOGICAL SUCCESSION

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Henry Chandler Cowles (1869–1939)

BEFORE

1825 Adolphe Dureau de la Malle coins the term “succession” when describing new growth in forest cuttings.

1863 Austrian botanist Anton Kerner publishes a study of plant succession in the Danube river basin.

AFTER

1916 Frederic Clements suggests that communities settle into a climax, or stable equilibrium, at the end of a succession period.

1977 Ecologists Joe Connell and Ralph Slatyer argue that succession occurs in diverse ways, highlighting facilitation (preparing the way for later species), tolerance (of lower resources), and inhibition (resisting competitors).

The Indiana Dunes comprise a windswept section of shifting sand along the southern shore of Lake Michigan, US. In 1896, American botanist Henry Chandler Cowles saw these dunes for the first time, and so began his career in the emerging field of ecology. Dunes are among some of the planet’s